

Chapter 71

Animating in Fusion's Keyframes Editor

This chapter covers how you can keyframe effects in Fusion's Inspector and how you can edit clips, effects, and keyframes in the Keyframes Editor.

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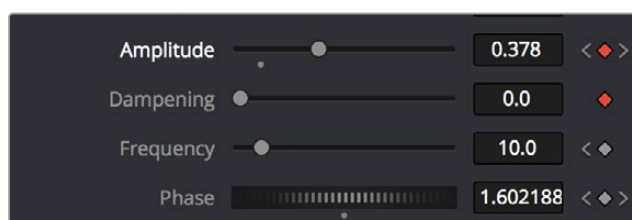
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Keyframing in the Inspector

Most parameters in most effects nodes can be keyframed in order to create animated effects such as animated transforms, rotoscoping with splines, dynamically altering warping behaviors, and more; the list is endless.

For convenience, a set of keyframing controls is available within the Inspector next to each keyframable parameter. These controls are:

- A gray Keyframe button to the right of each keyframable parameter. Clicking this gray button creates a keyframe at the current position of the playhead, and turns the button orange.
- Whenever the playhead is sitting right on top of a keyframe, this button turns orange. Clicking an orange Keyframe button deletes the keyframe at that frame and turns the button gray again.
- Small navigation arrows appear to the right and left if there are more keyframes in those directions. Clicking on navigation arrows to the right and left of keyframes jumps the playhead to those keyframes.



Orange Keyframe buttons in the Inspector show there's a keyframe at that frame

Once you've keyframed one or more parameters, if Show Modes/Options has been enabled, the node containing the parameters you keyframed displays a Keyframe badge to show that node has been animated.



A keyframed node displays a Keyframe badge in the Node Editor

Once you've started keyframing node parameters, you can edit their timing in the Keyframes Editor and/or Spline Editor.

Removing Animation in the Inspector

To remove a keyframed spline from a parameter:

- 1 Right-click the keyframe control of the parameter you want to remove animation from.
- 2 Choose Remove [Name of parameter] from the contextual menu.

Attaching a Parameter to an Existing Animation Curve

Multiple parameters can be connected to the same animation curve. This can be an invaluable timesaver if you are identically animating different parameters in a node.

To connect a second parameter to the same animation curve:

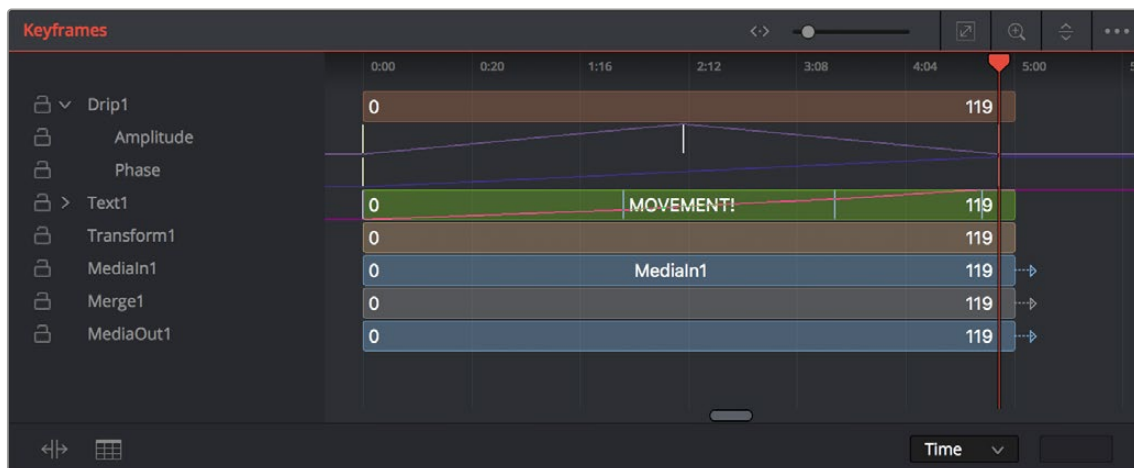
- 1 Right-click on the second parameter you want to attach.
- 2 In the contextual menu, hover over the Connect To submenu.
- 3 In the Connect To submenu, choose the name of the animated parameter.

Keyframes Editor Overview

The Keyframes Editor is essentially a timeline view of your composition, within which each clip and effect node in your composition is represented by a track. These tracks have the same color coding as the nodes they represent and are labeled where appropriate. A Time Ruler at the top indicates the timing of your composition, while numerous controls let you control the contents of the Keyframes Editor.

The Keyframes Editor can be used for one of two things:

- To adjust the timing of elements in a project, whether they're clips or effects. You can trim, slide, and extend clips, adjust the timing of an animation spline, or trim the duration of an effects node. You can freely rearrange the order of nodes in the Timeline without affecting the layering order of your composition. All compositing operations are handled in the Node Editor, while the Keyframes Editor manages the timing of your composition.
- To create and/or edit keyframes that you've applied to effects in a track-based manner, you can retime keyframes, add and delete keyframes, and even edit keyframe values



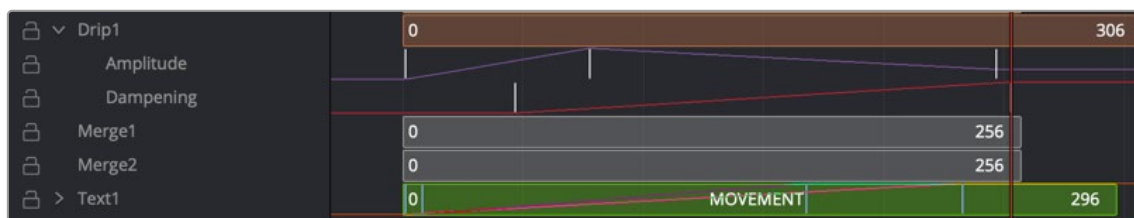
The Keyframes Editor

To show the Keyframes Editor, do one of the following:

- Click the Keyframes Editor button in the UI toolbar to toggle visibility of the Keyframes Editor on and off.
- Press F7 on the keyboard.

Keyframes Editor Tracks

While each clip and effect node in your composition is represented by a track, keyframed parameters are exposed either as keyframes superimposed upon the track to which they're applied (as seen on the MOVEMENT track), or they can be opened up onto their own tracks for more precise editing, one keyframe track per keyframed parameter, by clicking a disclosure control to the left of that track's name in the Timeline header (as seen under the "Drip1" track).



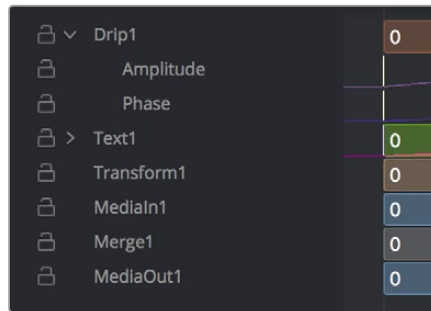
The Timeline tracks

The Timeline Header

The Timeline header area on the left side of the Timeline is a hierarchical list of all tracks in a composition. Each track displays the name of its corresponding node, a lock button, and a disclosure control for revealing keyframe tracks for each keyframe animation, modifier, and mask that's attached to it.

Collapse/Open All

A quick way to open or close all available keyframe tracks at once is to use the Expand/Collapse Tool Controls commands in the Keyframe Timeline Option menu.

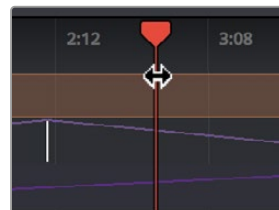


The Timeline header area

The Playhead

As elsewhere in Fusion, the playhead is a red vertical bar that runs through the Timeline view to indicate the position of the current frame or time. The Keyframes Editor playhead is locked to the viewer playhead, so the image you're viewing is in sync.

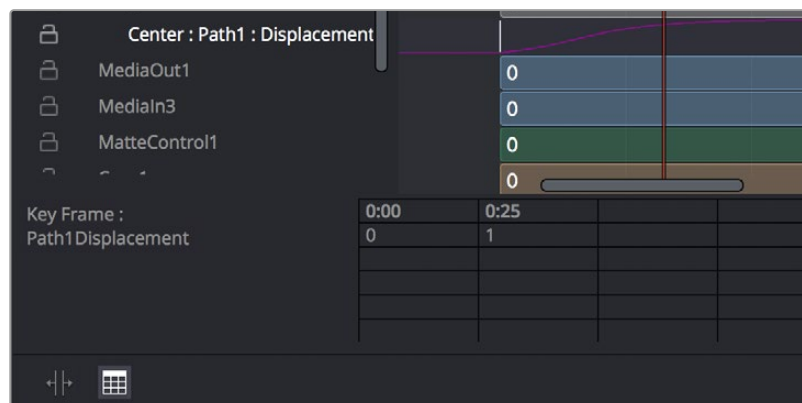
You must click on the playhead directly to drag it, even within the Timeline ruler (clicking and dragging anywhere else in the Timeline ruler scales the Timeline). Additionally, you can jump the playhead to a new location by holding down the Command-Option keys and clicking in the track area (not the Timeline ruler).



The playhead about to be dragged by the pointer

Spreadsheet

If you turn on the Spreadsheet and then click on the name of a layer in the keyframe track, the numeric time position and value (or values if it's a multi-dimensional parameter) of each keyframe appear as entries in the cells of the Spreadsheet. Each column represents one keyframe, while each row represents a single aspect of each keyframe.

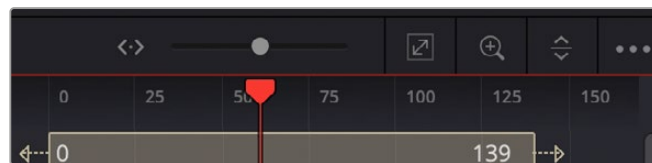


Editing keyframes in the Spreadsheet

For example, if you're animating a blur, then the Key Frame row shows the frame each keyframe is positioned at, and the Blur1BlurSize row shows the blur size at each keyframe. If you change the Key Frame value of any keyframe, you'll move that keyframe to a new frame of the Timeline.

Scaling and Panning the Timeline

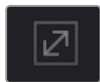
At the top, a series of zoom and framing controls let you adjust the work area containing the layers.



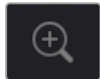
The Keyframe Editor framing controls



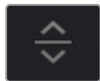
A Horizontal zoom control lets you scale the size of the editor.



A Zoom to Fit button fits the width of all tracks to the current width of the Keyframes Editor.



A Zoom to Rect tool lets you draw a rectangle to define an area of the Keyframes Editor to zoom into.



A Sort pop-up menu lets you sort or filter the tracks in various ways.



An Option menu provides access to many other ways of filtering tracks and controlling visible options.

Working with Segments in the Timeline

Most of the work in the Timeline involves trimming and aligning clip segments.

To select a single segment in the Timeline, do one of the following:

- Click the node's name in the header.
- Click the node's segment in the Timeline.

To add another segment to the selection, do one of the following:

- Hold Command and click additional segments to select discontinuous selections.
- Select a segment, and then hold Shift and click another segment to make a contiguous selection of all segments in between.

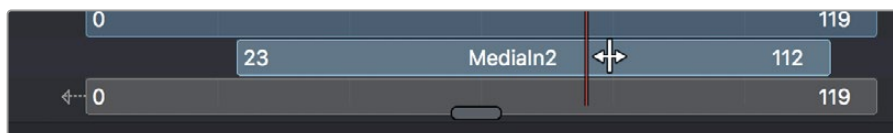
To remove a segment from the selection, do the following:

- Hold Command and click a selected segment to deselect it.

TIP: Selecting a node's name from the Timeline header also selects the node's tile in the Node Editor, with its controls displayed in the Inspector.

Moving Segments in the Timeline

To move the position of a segment, drag on the node's segment in the Keyframes Editor. The cursor will resemble a bar with two arrows pointing in either direction. Moving a segment changes where that clip begins and ends in the composition.



The Move cursor

Trimming Segments

Trimming segments has different effects on Loaders, MediaIn and Effect nodes:

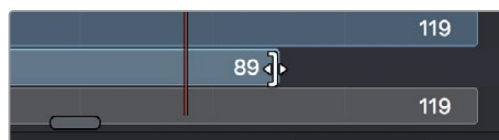
- Trimming a Loader or MediaIn node is similar to trimming clips in an editing application, in that you're changing the in and out points of the range of media that clip makes available to your composition.
- Trimming the segments of effect nodes instead modifies the range of that node's effect in the composition. Outside of the trimmed region, that effect node will behave as if it were disabled.

TIP: Shortening the duration of effects nodes can optimize processing. Imagine a Loader or MediaIn node that represents a clip that's 100 frames long and is connected to a Defocus node that's animated from frames 80–100. There is little to no point in processing the defocus node between frames 0–79, so trimming the defocus segment to start at frame 80 in the Timeline will effectively prevent it from rendering and consuming either memory or processor time until needed.

To trim a segment in the Timeline, do the following:

- Drag on either end of the node's segment in the Timeline.

The cursor changes to a vertical bar with a single arrow when the cursor is in the right location to trim.



The Trim cursor

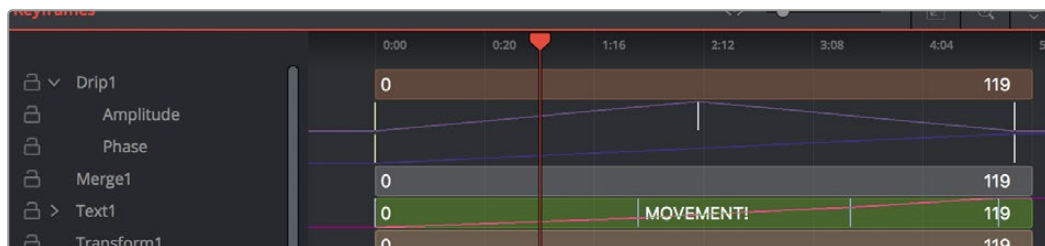
Holding the First or Last Frame

If you want to hold a Loader's first or last frame of a clip for a certain number of frames, also called a freeze frame, you can hold Command while you drag beyond the first or last of the segment in the Timeline.

Working with Keyframes in the Timeline

Keyframes can be drawn in one of two ways. When keyframe tracks are closed, they're drawn over the node's segment. Clicking on the disclosure icon to the left of the node's name in the track header expands the display so each keyframed parameter has its own track in the Timeline, enabling precise editing.

Furthermore, each keyframe track, whether open or closed, exposes a miniature curve overlay that provides a visual representation of the rise and fall of keyframed values. This little overlay isn't directly editable.



The Drip1 segment has its keyframe tracks exposed, while the Text1 segment has its keyframe tracks collapsed so they're displayed within the segment.

Drag and Drop Keyframe Editing

Here are pointer-based keyframe editing methods that will get you started.

Methods of selecting keyframes:

- Click a single keyframe to select it.
- Drag a bounding box over a series of keyframes to select them all.
- Command-click to select discontinuous keyframes.
- Shift-click the first and last of a range of keyframes to select a contiguous range.

Methods of adjusting keyframes:

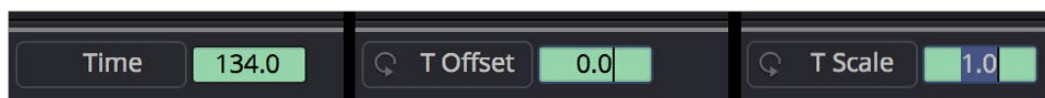
- You can drag keyframes left and right to reposition them in time.
- You can right-click one or more selected keyframes and use contextual menu commands to change keyframe interpolation, copy/paste keyframes, or even create new keyframes.

Keyframe Editing Using the Time Editor

A drop-down and editing field at the bottom right of the Keyframes Editor lets you numerically edit the timing, in frames, of any selected keyframe, making it easy to make precise adjustments.

To change the position of a keyframe using the toolbar, do one of the following:

- Select a keyframe, and then enter a new frame number in the Time Edit box.
- Choose T Offset from the Time Editor drop-down, select one or more keyframes, and enter a frame offset.
- Choose T Scale from the Time Editor drop-down, select one or more keyframes, and enter a frame offset.



The Time button can switch to Time Offset or Time Scale for moving keyframes.

The Keyframe Spreadsheet

If you turn on the Spreadsheet and then click on the name of a layer in the keyframe track, the numeric time position and value (or values if it's a multi-dimensional parameter) of each keyframe appear as entries in the cells of the Spreadsheet. Each column represents one keyframe, while each row represents a single aspect of each keyframe.



Editing keyframes in the Spreadsheet

For example, if you're animating a blur, then the Key Frame row shows the frame each keyframe is positioned at, and the Blur1BlurSize row shows the blur size at each keyframe. If you change the Key Frame value of any keyframe, you'll move that keyframe to a new frame of the Timeline.

Duplicating Spline Keyframes

Keyframes can be duplicated, either onto the same keyframe track or onto different tracks. This can save you time if you need to repeat a keyframe sequence at another time on the same segment, or even just create identically-timed keyframes on two different segments.

To duplicate keyframes, do the following:

- 1 Select one or more keyframes you want to duplicate.
- 2 Hold Command and drag one of the selected keyframes to a new position.

Time Stretching Keyframes

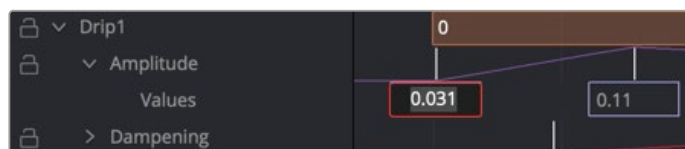
If you select a range of keyframes in a keyframe track, you can turn on the Time Stretch tool in the lower left of the Keyframes Editor, to show a box you can use to squeeze and stretch the entire range of keyframes relative to one another, to change the overall timing of a sequence of keyframes without losing the relative timing from one keyframe to the next. Alternatively, you can turn on Time Stretch and draw a bounding box around the keyframes you want to adjust to create a time-stretching boundary that way. Click the Time Stretch tool again to turn it off.



Time stretching keyframes

Showing Keyframe Values

When a node and its accompanying segment have animated parameters, keyframes appear as colored tick marks in keyframe tracks to indicate when animated changes occur. If the tracks and splines are open on a parameter, choosing Show Values from the Keyframes Editor Option menu shows editable fields beneath each keyframe. These fields show each keyframe's current value and allow you to edit them simply by entering a new number.



Show values from the Keyframes Editor Option menu

Timeline Filters

When a composition grows to include hundreds of nodes, locating specific node layers can quickly become difficult. Timeline filters can be created and applied to sift out nodes that are not necessary to the current operation. The Global Timeline preferences include a number of pre-made filters that you can enable, or you can create new ones as needed.

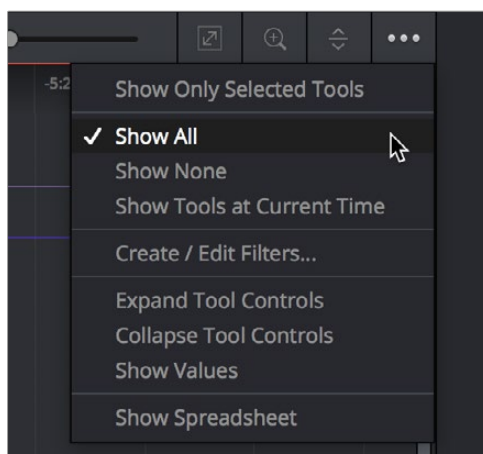
To use a Timeline filter:

Open the Keyframes Editor Option menu and choose an item from the top of the menu. Default Timeline filters include;

- Show All, which shows all node layers in the current composition.
- Show None, which hides all layers.
- Show Tools at Current Time, which only displays node layers under the playhead.
- If you've created custom filters, they appear here as well, in alphabetical order.

To go back to showing everything:

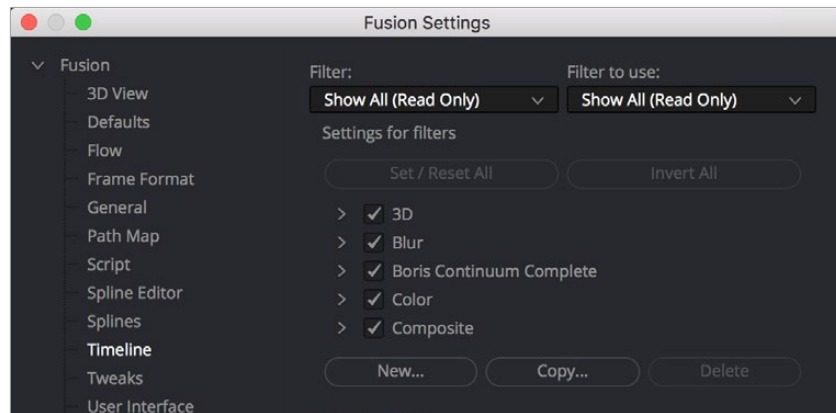
- Choose Show All from the Keyframes Editor Option menu. All layers will reappear.



Choosing a Timeline filter

To create a Timeline filter:

- 1 Choose Create/Edit Filters from the Keyframes Editor Option menu to open the Timeline panel of the Fusion Settings window. This is where you can create new Timeline filters.



The Global Timeline preferences for enabling filters

- 2 Click the New button, enter a name for your new filter setting, and click OK. The filter you created is now selected in the Filter pop-up menu at the top.
- 3 Use the “Settings for filters” list to turn on the checkboxes of nodes you want to be seen and turn off the checkboxes of nodes you want to filter out. Each category of node can be turned on and off, or you can open up a category’s disclosure control to turn individual nodes on and off. Clicking Invert All immediately turns off all node categories.
- 4 When you’re finished creating filters, click the Save button to hide the Fusion Settings window.

Filters that you’ve created in the Timeline panel of the Fusion Settings window appear in the Keyframes Editor Option menu.

To delete a filter:

- 1 Choose Create/Edit Filters from the Keyframes Editor Option menu to open the Timeline panel of the Fusion Settings window. This is where you can delete Timeline filters.
- 2 Choose the filter you want to delete from the Filter pop-up menu.
- 3 Click the Delete button, and when a dialog asks if you really want to do that, click OK.

Selected Filtering

Choosing “Show only selected tools” from the Keyframes Editor Option menu filters out all segments except for layers corresponding to selected nodes. This option can be turned on or off.

TIP: When “Show only selected tools” is enabled, you can continue to select nodes in the Node Editor to update what’s displayed in the Keyframes Editor.

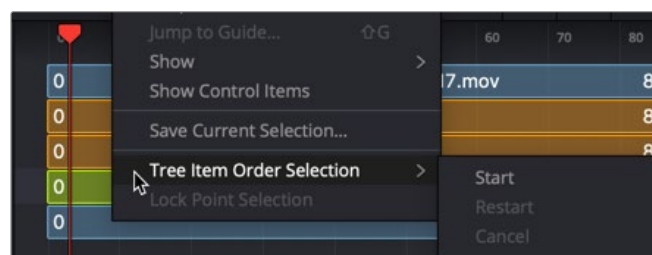
Sorting in the Timeline

You can change the order in which the nodes are displayed from top to bottom in the Timeline.

- You can use the Tree Item Order Selection menu to sort the tracks by an assigned number.
- You can use the Sort pop-up menu.

The Tree Item Order Menu

Right-clicking over any track on the Keyframes Editor will display a contextual menu that contains the Tree Item Order Selection submenu. Choosing Start from the submenu allows you to start numbering each item in the track header by clicking on them. The first item you click will be #1, the second item #2, the third #3, and so on. Once you have selected all the items in the order you want them to be organized in the Keyframes Editor, right-click over a track, and from the Tree Item Order Selection submenu, choose End. The items will be ordered using the assigned numbers, with #1 appearing above #2, which appears above #3, and so on. The first items in the Keyframe track list will always be the nodes that are the root of the node tree. The numbered nodes will appear in order after the root nodes. For example, if the node tree starts with a background node, and then connects to a Fast Noise, Blur, and Color Corrector, the background node will always appear at the top of the Keyframes Editor track list because it is the root node.

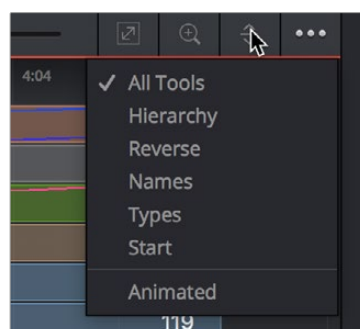


The Keyframes Editor Tree Item Order Selection menu

If you begin numbering nodes in the track header and change your mind or decide on a different order, you can choose Restart to begin numbering again or choose Cancel to keep the current order.

The Sort Menu

The Sort menu reorders how the layers of each node appear in the Keyframes Editor. Setting the menu back to All Tools will display them in a linear order, scanning the Node Editor from left to right and top to bottom. This is the default setting.



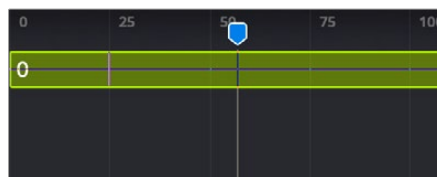
The Timeline Sort Order menu

- **All Tools:** Forces all tools currently in the Node Editor to be displayed in the Keyframes Editor.

- **Hierarchy:** Sorts with the most background layers at the top of the header, through to the most foreground layers at the bottom, following the connections of the nodes in the Node Editor.
- **Reverse:** The opposite of Hierarchy, working backward from the last node in the Node Editor toward the most background source node.
- **Names:** Sorts by the alphabetical order of the nodes, starting at the top with the beginning of the alphabet.
- **Start:** Orders layers based on their starting point in the composition. Nodes that start earlier in the Global project time are listed at the top of the header, while nodes that start later are at the bottom.
- **Animated:** Restricts the Timeline to showing animated layers only. This is an excellent mode to use when adjusting the timing of animations on several nodes at once.

Markers

Markers help identify important frames in a project that might affect how you keyframe animation. They may indicate the frame where a dragon breathes fire at a protagonist, the moment that someone passes through a portal, or any other important frame in a composition that you need to keep track of. Markers added to the Timeline in the Cut, Edit, Fairlight, or Color page will appear in the Keyframes Editor and Spline Editor of the Fusion page. They can also be added from the Keyframes Editor or the Spline Editor while working in Fusion Studio or the Fusion page. Markers in Fusion appear as a small handle with a line extending vertically through the graph view when selected.



A marker being moved in the Keyframed Editor

To create a marker, do the following:

Right-click at a frame in the Timeline Ruler of the Keyframes Editor and choose Add Marker from the contextual menu.

The most important attribute of a marker is its position. For it to add value, a marker must be placed on the frame you intended it to be on. Hovering the cursor over a marker displays a tooltip with its current frame position. If it is on the wrong frame, you can drag it along the Time Ruler to reposition it.

Markers added to the Time Ruler are editable in the Fusion page, and the changes appear back in the other DaVinci Resolve pages. Time Ruler markers can be added, moved, deleted, renamed, and given descriptive notes from within Fusion's Keyframes or Spline Editor.

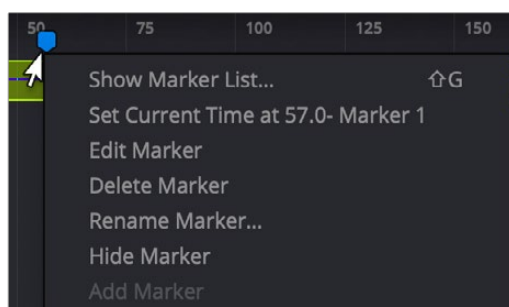
NOTE: Markers attached to clips in the Edit page Timeline are visible on MediaIn nodes in Fusion's Keyframes Editor but not editable. They are not visible in the Spline Editor.

Jumping to Markers

Double-clicking a marker jumps the playhead to that marker's position.

Renaming Markers

By default, a marker uses the frame number in its name, but you can give it a more descriptive name to go along with the frame number, making it easier to identify. To rename a marker in Fusion, right-click over the marker and choose Rename Guide from the contextual menu. Enter a name in the dialog and click OK.



The Marker contextual menu is accessed by right-clicking over a marker or Keyframe Editor Time Ruler.

Show Marker List

Markers can be used to jump to specific locations in a composition using the Marker List. If you right-click over a marker or within the Keyframe Editor Time Ruler to bring up the contextual menu, you can choose Show Marker List, or press Shift-G, to display the Marker List dialog. The Marker List is a floating dialog that will remain on top of the main window until closed.

The Marker List shows all the current markers in the composition, listed according to their position in time along with any custom name you've given them. If you double-click a marker's name from the list, the playhead jumps to the marker's location.



The Marker List dialog allows you to navigate through a composition using markers.

There is a pair of checkboxes beside the names of each marker. One is for the Spline Editor, and one is for the Keyframes Editor. By default, markers are shown in both the Spline Editor and Keyframes Editor, but you can deselect the appropriate checkbox to hide the markers in that view.

Deleting Markers

You can delete a marker by dragging it up beyond the Time Ruler and releasing the mouse. You can also use the marker's contextual menu to choose Delete Marker.

Autosnap

To help with precisely positioning keyframes and the start and end of segments as you drag in the Timeline, you can have them snap to a field, a frame, or to markers. The Autosnap option is accessed through the Options section in the Keyframes Editor's contextual menu. There are two submenu options for autosnapping. One option controls the snapping behavior when you drag keyframes, control points, or the starting and ending edges of segments. The other option controls the snapping behavior of markers.

Autosnap Points

When you drag keyframes or the edges of segments, often you want them to fall on a specific frame. Autosnap restricts the placement of keyframes and segment edges to frame boundaries by default, but you have other options found in the contextual menu. To configure autosnapping on keyframes and segment edges, right-click anywhere within the Keyframes Editor and choose Options > Autosnap Points from the contextual menu. This will display the Autosnap Points submenu with options for the snapping behavior. The options are:

None: None allows free positioning of keyframes and segment edges with subframe accuracy.

Frame: Frame forces keyframes and segment edges to snap to the nearest frame.

Field: Field forces keyframes and segment edges to snap to the nearest field, which is 0.5 of a frame.

Guides: When enabled, the keyframes and segment edges snap to markers.

Autosnap Markers

When you click to create a new marker, the default behavior is that it will snap to the closest frame. If you reposition the marker, it also snaps to the nearest frame as you drag. This behavior can be changed in the Keyframes Editor's contextual menu by choosing from the Options > Autosnap Markers submenu. The options are:

None: Markers can be placed anywhere with subframe accuracy.

Frame: Frame forces all markers to snap to the nearest frame.

Field: Field forces all markers to snap to the nearest field.

The Spreadsheet Editor

The Spreadsheet Editor is a separate panel that can be displayed beneath the Keyframes Editor. It is used to compactly show the numeric values of the keyframes for selected parameters in the Keyframes Editor's header, via a table with rows and columns, showing time and value.

To reveal the Spreadsheet Editor, click on the Spreadsheet button in the toolbar. The Spreadsheet will split the Work Area panel and appear below the Keyframes Editor's interface.



The Spreadsheet Editor showing editable data for six keyframes

Selecting a Node to Edit

To display a node's timing in the Spreadsheet, select the node's name in the Keyframes Editor header. The Start and End points of the selected node will appear in the keyframe's line of the Spreadsheet.

To edit an animation parameter in the Spreadsheet Editor, select the parameter in the Keyframes Editor header. The keyframe row includes a box for each frame number that contains a keyframe. The value of the keyframe is displayed in the cell below the frame number. Clicking on a cell allows you to change the frame number the keyframe is on or the parameter's value for that keyframe.

78.0	213.0	247.0
0.11	0.055	0.055

Clicking on the parameter's keyframe value allows you to change it

TIP: Entering a frame number using a decimal point (e.g., 10.25 or 15.75) allows you to set keyframes on a subframe level to create more natural animations.

Inserting Keyframes

You can also add new keyframes to an animation by clicking in an empty keyframe cell and entering the desired time for the new keyframe. Using the cell under the new keyframe, you can enter a value for the parameter.

Selecting Multiple Nodes to Edit

Multiple splines and nodes can be edited together in the Spreadsheet. By default, selecting a new parameter in the Timeline header will replace the parameter and keyframes currently listed in the Spreadsheet Editor. Holding down Command, you can click on additional parameters on different nodes to add them to the Spreadsheet.

Customizing the Keyframes Editor

There are a few ways you can change the appearance of the Keyframes Editor to better fit your needs. All these options are found by right-clicking anywhere within the Keyframes Editor and choosing an option from the contextual menu that appears.

Line Size

The Line Size option controls the height of each Timeline segment individually. It is often useful to increase the height of a Timeline bar, especially when editing or manipulating complex splines.

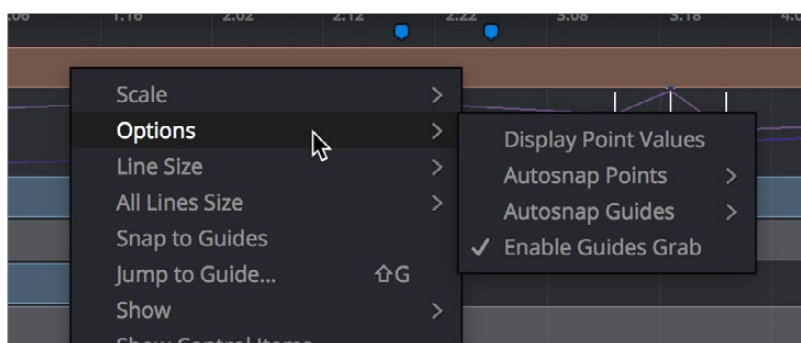
Methods of increasing or decreasing the height of segments:

To change the height of just one segment: Right-click anywhere within the Keyframes Editor and choose a size from the Line Size submenu. The options are Minimum, Small, Medium, Large, and Huge.

To change the height of all segments: Right-click anywhere within the Keyframes Editor and choose a size from the All Line Size submenu. The options are Minimum, Small, Medium, Large, and Huge.

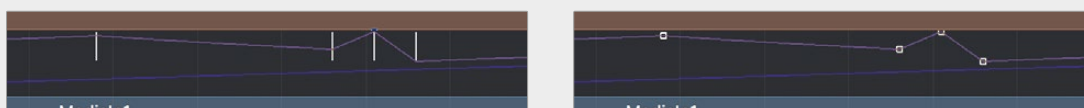
Display Point Values

A more traditional view of keyframes is to view them as control points instead of vertical bars, making them easier to select for some people. From the Timeline contextual menu, you can right-click anywhere within the Keyframes Editor and choose Options > Display Point Values to change how keyframes look.



The Options submenu for changing Display Point Values

Here are the two options, compared.



Keyframes displayed as bars (left), and keyframes displayed as Point Values (right).

Displaying Audio Waveforms

You can display a MediaIn node's audio waveform in the Keyframes Editor and use it as a guide as you add and move keyframes.



Waveforms are displayed in the Keyframes Editor for all MediaIn nodes

To display the audio waveform in the Keyframes Editor:

- 1 Open the Keyframes Editor.
- 2 Click the disclosure arrow next to the MediaIn node to view the audio waveform for that clip.

To change the size of an audio waveform display:

- 1 Open the Keyframes Editor.
- 2 In the Keyframes Editor, select the audio track of the waveform you want to modify.
- 3 Right-click over the audio waveform and choose Line Size > Minimum/Small/Medium/Large/Huge.
- 4 When using Fusion Studio, you can view the audio waveforms in the Keyframes Editor by displaying the Saver node.

To view the Audio Waveform in Fusion Studio, do the following:

- 1 Open the Keyframes Editor.
- 2 Expand the Saver track to view the audio waveform.

When you want to find the precise location of an audio beat, transient, or cue, you can slowly drag over the audio waveform to hear the audio. If you need to see more resolution in the waveform display, you can increase the size.

To change the size of an audio waveform display:

- 1 Open the Keyframes Editor.
- 2 Right-click over the audio waveform and choose Line Size > Minimum/Small/Medium/Large/Huge.

TIP: Right-clicking a track in the Keyframes Editor and choosing All Line Size > Minimum/Small/Medium/Large/Huge changes all the tracks and audio waveforms in the Keyframes Editor.